

OVERVIEW – Top 10 Issues Facing Educators

The 2026 WNC Educator Survey makes the picture clear: 85% of the faculty who engage with AI are already using these tools, 65% say their institution's policy is behind or nonexistent, and 92% name loss of critical thinking as their leading concern. Students feel the pressure too. Roughly 70% of college students now see AI as a danger to their future careers.

One principle ties all ten issues together, simple enough for a sticky note:

Brain first, then AI.

Used well, AI extends what a capable person can do. Used as a substitute for learning, it removes the work that builds human understanding and capability in the first place.

1. Critical Thinking Skills. True understanding cannot be fast-tracked; it is a deliberate, deeply human process of piecing together complex puzzles to understand and solve real-world problems. While AI provides an illusion of instant learning, education must focus on cultivating the deep critical thinking skills required to evaluate AI output, while still teaching the foundational skills.

2. Guidance Over Prohibition. Students use AI at home no matter what the syllabus says. Banning it ends the chance to teach good judgment around using it. The educators with the best results bring AI into the open and frame it clearly as a tool for learning and not a replacement.

3. Policy Built for a Fast-Moving Target. 65% of WNC educators say their policy is behind or absent. The cause is structural: technology changes way faster than policy can keep up. The best schools treat policy as a living document and get input from front line educators on which way to move.

4. Teaching Students to Judge AI Output. AI never tells you when it is wrong, hallucinations are a common issue. A fabricated citation looks exactly like a real one. Critical evaluation of AI output is a literacy problem, and it is a skill that belongs in every discipline.

5. Assessment Must Shift to Process. A model can produce a competent final paper in under a minute. Educators who grade only the final product end up measuring the tool, not the student. 60% of WNC educators have already redesigned assignments toward evaluating the process.

6. Workplace Preparation Creates Tension. Employers are beginning to expect AI proficiency. But learning requires students to solve the issues themselves. A phased approach to AI introduction ensures students learn foundational skills without becoming dependent on AI in the process.

7. Training Faculty for Appropriate Use. Faculty want training and direction, not just access to models. Only 25% of WNC institutions have invested in a dedicated AI tool for their faculty.

8. AI as Institutional Infrastructure. Schools across WNC run AI for chatbots, enrollment systems, and administrative work. Done poorly, it routes a student in real need to a bot that cannot help, good customer relation management requires offering mixed help desk support, depending on the issue at hand. Also, 60% of educators flagged data privacy directly as a concern.

9. Collaboration Beats Silos. Campuses making real progress share strategies and build common frameworks. The Land of Sky regional summits are the kind of infrastructure that makes it possible.

10. AI cannot replace physical place or human connection: In-person settings produce stronger engagement, better retention, and relationships that change a student's path. Learning ultimately works best in an engaging and cooperative environment, with active participation from students and educators.